

Introduction to Comparative Politics

Instructor: Alexander Trubowitz

Email address:

Office Hours: TBA

Overview: This course introduces undergraduate students to the causes and consequences of variation in political institutions around the world. Why do states emerge in the first place, and what accounts for the dramatic differences in states' ability to impose order and implement policies within the territorial boundaries they claim to control? Under what conditions do elections grant ordinary citizens genuine influence over policy and when are elites able to control the outcomes of ostensibly democratic processes? How did European states acquire the ability to conquer most of the world by the early twentieth century, and why did these European empires collapse under pressure from anticolonial and nationalist mobilization? Why are some states able to accommodate or control national and ethnic differences while others collapse in civil war and secessionist violence? How does variation in state capacity affect the prospects for economic development?

The aims of this course are twofold. The first goal is to equip students with a substantive command of key problems in political development that will be relevant for subsequent coursework and research in comparative politics, international relations, and development economics. The second is to train students in the basic tools of social-scientific inquiry: how to identify variation in key outcomes between or within states and to generate convincing explanations for these differences.

Requirements:

Weekly reading: Students are expected to complete the week's readings before the first lecture of the week. The assigned material amounts to 60–70 pages per week, involving excerpts from longer scholarly works.

In-class midterm (Week 7): multiple choice, short answer, and essay. 30% of course grade.

In-class final exam: multiple choice, short answer, and essay. 30% of course grade.

Short paper (Week 7): James Madison wrote that “You must first enable the government to control the governed; and in the next place oblige it to control itself.” Is Madison right about the appropriate sequence, or does he have it backwards? Why? Be sure to critically assess the alternative position. 5–7 pages, double spaced. 25% of your grade, based on the written paper and a meeting with me following its submission. More detailed guidelines circulated separately.

Participation: active participation in class based on prior engagement with the readings is expected and is worth 15% of your course grade. In this course, we will uphold the university's code of conduct and values regarding open intellectual inquiry and equal respect for all class members.

Prerequisites: None.

Electronic devices: Laptops are permitted for note-taking and for referring to course readings. Please be conscious of the fact that browsing the internet during class is distracting for the students sitting around you. If you plan to browse the internet during class time, expect to be called upon!

Plagiarism: Plagiarism is a serious breach of the University's code of conduct. It is assumed that you have carefully reviewed the University's policy on plagiarism. Your use of AI must adhere to the university's policy. Please note that you are unlikely to succeed on the midterm and final exam if you have not studied the readings in detail and thought about them yourself. Likewise, you need to be able to display ownership over the ideas expressed in your paper in our one-on-one meeting to receive a high grade. This will be considerably easier if you have written the paper yourself.

Accessibility: The University is committed to equal access for students with disabilities. Students with disabilities who have been approved to receive academic accommodations by the University must contact me as soon as possible so that the relevant accommodations can be made.

Week 1: Explaining variation in states and regimes (2 lectures). Along what dimensions do governments around the world vary? How should we go about explaining this variation as social scientists?

Tilly, Charles. *Regimes and Repertoires*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2006 (selections).

Geddes, Barbara. *Paradigms and Sand Castles: Theory Building and Research Design in Comparative Politics*. Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 2003 (selections).

Week 2: The origins of political order (2 lectures). How does political hierarchy emerge? Is there a way to reconcile accounts based on consent and those based on coercion? Why might rulers need the consent of some in order to successfully coerce others?

Hobbes, Thomas. *Leviathan*. Ed. Richard Tuck. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996 (selections).

Weber, Max. *Economy and Society*. Ed. and trans. Keith Tribe. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2019 (selections).

North, Douglass. *Structure and Change in Economic History*. New York: Norton, 1981 (selections).

Week 3: Power-sharing between rulers and elites (2 lectures). Why can't rulers in non-democratic countries do whatever they want? Under what conditions do rulers grant a say over policy to other actors?

Ertman, Thomas. *Birth of the Leviathan: Building States and Regimes in Medieval and Early Modern Europe*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997 (selections).

Svolik, Milan. *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2012 (selections).

Garfias, Francisco, and Emily Sellars. "From conquest to centralization: Domestic conflict and the transition to direct rule." *The Journal of Politics* 83.3 (2021): 992-1009.

Week 4: Power-sharing and state capacity (2 lectures). When do power-sharing institutions favor the development of state capacity and when do they impede its development? Why might elites have an interest in thwarting the extension of central state authority?

Blaydes, Lisa, and Eric Chaney. "The feudal revolution and Europe's rise: Political divergence of the Christian west and the Muslim world before 1500 CE." *American Political Science Review* 107.1 (2013): 16-34.

Dincecco, Mark. "The rise of effective states in Europe." *Journal of Economic History* 75.3 (2015): 901-918.

Grafe, Regina. *Distant tyranny: markets, power, and backwardness in Spain, 1650-1800*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2012 (selections).

Week 5: Territorial rivals and state consolidation (2 lectures). How do rulers deal with regional rivals within the territory of a state? When are bargains struck that grant rivals control over their regions, and when does the ruler succeed in imposing direct control over previously autonomous regions?

Boone, Catherine. *Political Topographies of the African State: Territorial Authority and Institutional Choice*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2003 (selections).

Ziblatt, Daniel. *Structuring the State: The Formation of Italy and Germany and the Puzzle of Federalism*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2006 (selections).

Saylor, Ryan. *State Building in Boom Times: Commodities and Coalitions in Latin America and Africa*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2014 (selections).

Week 6: From power-sharing to democratization (2 lectures). When do power-sharing institutions become broadly inclusive or democratic, granting ordinary citizens a say over policy? Is inequality the key explanatory variable? When might elites have self-interested reasons to support democratization?

Boix, Carles. *Democracy and redistribution*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2003 (selections).

Ansell, Ben, and David Samuels. *Inequality and democratization: An elite-competition approach*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2014 (selections).

Thompson, Henry. *Food and Power: Regime Type, Agricultural Policy, and Political Stability*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2019 (selections).

Week 7: The design of democratic institutions (2 lectures). Why doesn't the introduction of mass suffrage necessarily lead to policy outcomes that correspond to the demands of ordinary citizens? How can elites manipulate the design of ostensibly democratic institutions to protect their interests?

Art, David. *The Resilience of the Old Regime: Paths Around Democracy in Europe, 1832–1919*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2026 (selections).

Albertus, Michael, and Victor Menaldo. *Authoritarianism and the Elite Origins of Democracy*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2017 (selections).

Ahmed, Amel. *Democracy and the Politics of Electoral System Choice: Engineering Electoral Dominance*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2013 (selections).

Week 8: Party systems and democratic consolidation (2 lectures). How does the structure of the political party system affect the viability of newly democratized regimes? Are the prospects for democratic consolidation helped or hurt if elites are able to protect their interests against redistributive pressure?

Ziblatt, Daniel. *Conservative Parties and the Birth of Democracy*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2017 (selections).

Riedl, Rachel. *Authoritarian Origins of Democratic Party Systems in Africa*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2014 (selections).

Naseemullah, Adnan, and Pradeep Chhibber. *Righteous Demagogues: Populist Politics in South Asia and Beyond*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2019 (selections).

Week 9: Forms of distributive conflict (2 lectures). When does distributive conflict take the form of political competition over taxation and social spending, and when does it take other forms? How does state capacity affect the form that distributive conflict takes?

Esping-Andersen, Gøsta. *Politics Against Markets: The Social Democratic Road to Power*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1985 (selections).

Boone, Catherine. "Electoral populism where property rights are weak: Land politics in contemporary sub-Saharan Africa." *Comparative Politics* 41.2 (2009): 183-201.

Chandra, Kanchan. *Why Ethnic Parties Succeed: Patronage and Ethnic Head Counts in India*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2004 (selections).

Week 10: Empire and colonialism (2 lectures). Why might a state distinguish between the residents of some of its territories (citizens) and those of its other territories (imperial or colonial subjects)? When do imperial or colonial states govern through local elites and when

do they establish direct administrative control over subject peoples? Why were European states able to conquer and subjugate most of the rest of the world by the early twentieth century?

Burbank, Jane, and Frederick Cooper. *Empires in World History: Power and the Politics of Difference*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2010 (selections).

Hoffman, Philip. *Why Did Europe Conquer the World?* Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2015 (selections).

Herbst, Jeffrey. *States and Power in Africa: Comparative Lessons in Authority and Control*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2000 (selections).

Week 11: Nationalism (2 lectures). Why do some people come to understand themselves as members of a common nation while others do not? Why do members of a common nation sometimes demand national autonomy and sometimes remain content with membership in a multinational state? To what extent did ideas of national self-determination that developed in Europe ultimately undermine European colonial rule around the world?

Hobsbawm, Eric. *Nations and nationalism since 1780. Programme, myth, reality*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990 (selections).

Hechter, Michael. *Alien Rule*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2013 (selections).

Lawrence, Adria. *Imperial Rule and the Politics of Nationalism: Anti-Colonial Protest in the French Empire*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2013 (selections).

Week 12: Secessionism and civil war (2 lectures). When do regional or ethnic groups demand secession, and when do secessionist demands result in civil war? Are ethnic differences a sufficient explanation for the outbreak of civil war? Why can't regional or ethnic demands always be accommodated through a political bargain granting partial autonomy?

Gagnon, V.P. *The Myth of Ethnic War: Serbia and Croatia in the 1990s*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2004 (selections).

Roessler, Philip. *Ethnic Politics and State Power in Africa: The Logic of the Coup-Civil War Trap*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2016 (selections).

Brancati, Dawn. "Decentralization: Fueling the fire or dampening the flames of ethnic conflict and secessionism?" *International Organization* 60.3 (2006): 651-685.

Week 13: The political economy of development (2 lectures). What are the key barriers to economic development and why might governments have a political incentive to preserve these barriers? Are secure property rights and the provision of public goods sufficient to achieve development, or must the state take a more interventionist role? How might colonial legacies affect states' ability to intervene effectively in the economy, and when might interventionist efforts backfire?

Besley, Timothy, and Torsten Persson. *Pillars of Prosperity: The Political Economics of Development Clusters*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2011 (selections).

Chang, Ha-Joon. *Kicking Away the Ladder: Development Strategy in Historical Perspective*. London: Anthem, 2002 (selections).

Kohli, Atul. *State-Directed Development: Political Power and Industrialization in the Global Periphery*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2002 (selections).